The Idiot Girl and the Flaming Tantrum of Death

By Laurie Notaro

My mother taught me TO APPRECIATE A JOB WELL DONE: "If you're going to kill each other, do it outside. I just finished cleaning."

My mother taught me LOGIC: "If you fall out of that swing and break your neck, you're not going to the store with me."

My mother taught me MEDICAL SCIENCE: "if you don't stop crossing your eyes, they are going to get stuck that way."

But most of all, my mother taught me WISDOM: "When you get to be my age, you'll understand."

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INTRODUCTION

Is it possible to see your mother [or grandmother] as a person – an entirely separate entity apart from her relationship to you? A person who sees the world through a totally unique and possibly quirky lens. A person full of humor, personality and an outrageousness all her own. Will you grow up to be like her? Laurie Notaro paints a vivid picture of herself as an older woman, navigating life in a college town that will make every young person stop and wonder, "What Flaming Tantrums of Death" is my own mother [or grandmother hiding? After all, she does drive a Prius . . .

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LAURIE: **(Pg 228-241)** My advice to you is that unless you really want to know just how old you are, a college campus is the last place you'd ever want to be. I was entirely unprepared for what I saw the first time I went to pick my husband up at the university. *(in shock, jaw dropping)* Those children are naked!

HUSBAND: It was cold this morning. You should have seen what happens on a hot day. It looks like lunchtime at a Roman bathhouse.

LAURIE: Why doesn't someone do something?

HUSBAND: *(laughing)* Like what?

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LAURIE: I don't know. Institute a 'clothing mandatory' rule? Napkins are not apparel! I would never wear that! She could at least have two bandanas, one for each chichi!

HUSBAND: The returning adult students don't dress like that. They dress like you.

LAURIE: *(to audience) (sound effect)* And just like that, with a long squeak and several pops, I felt the air dribble out of my coolness balloon, stopping every now and then to catch its breath.

HUSBAND: When was the last time you were on a college campus?

LAURIE: I don't know . . . Probably . . .

HUSBAND: Things have changed. You have insurance now AND you drive a Prius!

LAURIE: *(defensively)* So?!

HUSBAND: Can't be bad a** in a Prius.

LAURIE: Whatever . . . *(to audience)* But I had already realized that was true – in a Prius, no matter how you cut it, you have the ferocity of Lovey Howell in a floppy straw hat holding a mai tai. And besides, Eugene [Oregon] is a quiet little town full of old hippies, college

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professors, and solar-energy enthusiasts, naming their children insidiously damaging names [like] Ptolemy, Star and Alchemy. Eugene was ideal, until that day when I saw what youth really looked like instead of the way I remembered it.

I didn't feel any different than I did when I was 20. Okay, okay, maybe not 20. Thirty. I don't feel any different from when I was thirty. But then again, I bought a HUD house in a bad neighborhood across the street from a lady with a shelter's worth of diseased cats. 35. YES. Thirty-five. I don't feel any different from when I was 35. *(to husband)* I am still cool.

I loved my age now. I loved where I was and I loved driving a Prius. Several days later I was driving that same Prius back from the market. I was going about thirty miles per hour; so I braked a couple of times because Priuses are rather quiet cars and are no friend to the blind, people using iPods, people on cell phones and, sadly, squirrels. My concern, however, was not good news to the shiny, black Volkswagen Jetta behind me, which, to be frank, was acting a little like a bull, I'm

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a cow, and there's been an inappropriate amount of drinking going on.

I descended the hill and approached the street where I needed to make a right, put on my blinker, slowed down, and started to make the turn when the Jetta passed me, honking loudly, and the passenger – a college-aged hippie, screamed out the passenger window, "What the F___?" and threw her hands up. ***At me!***

She was young, I was not, and I was driving a Prius. To her, insulting me was the safest thing in the world. However . . .

The old lady in the spinless car who was hitting her brakes every ten seconds to keep the children and squirrels safe was the same girl who lived for nearly a decade in a craptastic neighborhood where she chased packs of wild dogs off her porch, hired local drug addicts as handymen and was entirely unafraid of two privileged brats in a brand-new German car.

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The brazen hippie chick in a black shiny Jetta had just activated the FLAMING TANTRUM OF DEATH.

Backstory: The Flaming Tantrum of Death was born one afternoon after witnessing one of the most spectacular hissy fits in world history. After a former acquaintance of mine decided that writing impolite bulletins about people and posting them on the Internet would be a productive use of spare time, there was no response from anyone targeted in the tirades. So, the author e-mailed the bulletins to those being insulted, including me, to ensure that they were seen – "Just in case you didn't notice my Flaming Tantrum of Death, here it is!"

Now, you can either become offended or see it as the high-caliber, Las Vegas -style entertainment that it is. The Flaming Tantrum of Death was spellbinding and spectacular in its absurdity. It raised anger and revenge to a new plateau, and with proper usage, it is something to aspire to, mixing 7th grade rage with the resilience of Tempur-Pedic technology. In awe of its inspiring power,

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I decided to take possession of it, deliver it from evil and use it only for good.

If you're wondering what a Flaming Tantrum of Death looks like in its physical form, it very much resembles me abandoning that right-hand turn and furiously flipping my car around to follow a shiny black Jetta and the hippies inside it, who were laughing . . . laughing . . . . LAUGHING at Lady Prius until they saw her directly behind them in their rearview mirror *(evil laugh)* They were stuck at a red light and never once thought that Lady Prius had the ability to terrorize anyone.

The Flaming Tantrum of Death progressed to its second stage. I laid on my horn. *(sound effect) (cackling)* Don't you love honking? You're so good at it, you little honkers! How 'bout I honk this horn until I get out of this fussy Prius, come over there and rip the hippie dreadlocks off your head?! *(to audience)* We all know I probably wasn't going to do that, but it sounded so good and dramatic, I had to say it.

Initially, both simply sat there dumbfounded as the horn blared until they decided upon their method of

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retaliation: the weapon of mass destruction known as "interpretive dance." *(demonstrate)* They began moving their arms and torsos from side to side and all around. They were ***dancing***!

(yelling) Is that all you've got? You're going to DANCE at me? Big horn honkers, "What the F___?" screamers, brazen tailgaters can only DANCE at me? Well dance to this! *(horn blaring)* And I laid on the horn again until the light turned green. They ran the next red trying to get away from me. I guess they were tired of dancing.

Now, I was fully aware that the next day's front-page headline was most likely to read: PRIUS OWNER NEEDS ANGER MANAGEMENT THERAPY AND A HUG, but I could not care less.

And just for the record, I am still looking for that car. It's a mall enough town. I'll find it. I happen to have some fire tantrum left in me – just enough to make some hippies dance.

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